According to the latest estimates, Hamas is currently holding 199 Israeli hostages. That in itself makes an invasion of the Gaza Strip virtually impossible. The hostages are Hamas's shield. For most Israelis, this is a horrible dilemma.

Hamas says that 500 patients were killed in the Israeli bombing of a hospital in Gaza City. Israel claims that the destruction resulted from a misfired rocket by Islamic Jihad. All Arab leaders who were supposed to meet with President Biden have since canceled their participation due to the hospital bombing.

Wednesday, October 18

Biden spent half a day in Israel in a show of solidarity. He relied on information from the Pentagon to say that the responsibility for the hospital explosion lay not on Israel, but "on the other team." He met with the families of hostages and promised to help negotiate their release. All in all, he showed extraordinary warmth in his speeches: "Contrarily to what happened in the Holocaust, this time you are not alone." He promised "unprecedented help" for Israel and $100 million for Gaza. He probably convinced Israel's war cabinet to allow humanitarian aid to enter Gaza and may have helped prevent an occupation of the enclave. "Think about what happens after victory," he said. His last speech ended with the words *Am Yisrael hai* ("The people of Israel live," a traditional Jewish slogan and song).

In the West, the major news outlets cautiously mention a "blast" in regard to the Al-Ahli Hospital, but the pictures of wounded and dead Palestinians tell a story of their own.

Skirmishes on the northern border and rockets on Kiryat Shmona, but nothing more for the time being. It seems that both Hezbollah and Israel are treading cautiously, as for both the price of a misstep could be high. Israel